



When We Talk About Literature. Notes on a Meeting of EURAMAL's Early Career Scholars (Oslo, September 25–29, 2025) (varia)

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**WHEN WE TALK ABOUT LITERATURE. NOTES ON A
MEETING OF EURAMAL'S EARLY CAREER SCHOLARS
(OSLO, SEPTEMBER 25–29, 2025)**

In the study of the humanities, questions often have a way of returning to us, transformed by time and new perspectives. Each generation of scholars revisits earlier debates with new urgencies, insights, and sometimes even vocabularies. What may appear as circular repetition is in fact a spiral movement, one that gathers insight from the past while opening fresh paths of thought. It is within this sense of movement and reflection that research renews itself and finds new directions of meaning. Propelled by this evolving dynamic, as early-career scholars of Arabic literature, we found ourselves asking: What do we learn from reading Arabic literature today? This shared question eventually became the axis of our roundtable at the Thirteenth Nordic Conference on Middle Eastern Studies in Oslo, and it unfolded further in a subsequent two-day workshop. The sense of continuity was provided through the persona of Stephan Guth, a professor of Arabic literature, who agreed to chair the roundtable and assisted us in organizing the workshop. He reminded us that a similar panel, which he had convened fifteen years earlier, posed a very similar question and ended up virtually predicting the 2011 upheaval in the region.

With a more modest ambition in mind, our idea for the Oslo roundtable and workshop emerged after the 2024 biennial conference of the European Association for Modern Arabic Literature (EURAMAL) in Prague. While such large gatherings offer invaluable exposure, they often leave little space for sustained dialogue. We wanted to create a space where PhD candidates and emerging researchers could think, write, and reflect alongside one another, and overcome the feeling of each working on a separate island. The process of preparation itself became a form of dialogue: initial brainstorming sessions between the two of us developed into wider exchanges with invited participants as we shaped a collective abstract and planned the workshop activities. These conversations revealed not only the variety of our intellectual backgrounds but also the constraints and particularities of our institutional contexts – a reminder of how differently Arabic literature is situated within European academia.

Even during the Oslo conference, the prominence of panels and keynote addresses from the fields of media studies, Islamic studies, and political science highlighted the relative marginalization of literary scholarship in Middle Eastern studies. This pattern

strengthened our conviction about the need to reassert and rethink the place of Arabic literature among the scholarly disciplines, and to continue evaluating how we read, study, and teach it. By revisiting what we discussed and discovered together in this report, we aim to reaffirm the value of collaboration, highlight the vitality of Arabic literature within broader humanistic inquiry, and invite others to join in this open, evolving dialogue.

1/ The Conference Roundtable

The roundtable invited a collective reflection on the question *What can we learn from reading Arabic literature?* – less an attempt to conclude or extract definitive answers than to rekindle a quest that continues to matter. The question itself carries a long philosophical history: Aristotle’s belief that literature, through mimesis, provides knowledge and catharsis; Plato’s worry that imitation distances us from truth. Over time, these foundational reflections shaped enduring tensions within literary studies: the balance between representation, effect, and ethical or epistemic value.

In the twentieth century, two main strands of thought emerged: the structuralists, who emphasized the autonomy of the text, understanding literature as a self-contained system of signs, and the critical theorists, who argued for reading works within their social, political, and economic contexts, often prioritizing questions of justice, ideology, and power. Critics, such as Umberto Eco in his essay “On Some Functions of Literature”, continue to reflect on «what use is this intangible power we call literature» (Eco & McLaughlin 2004:2) and argue that literature opens a transformative space in which readers negotiate meaning, interpret multiple perspectives, and encounter forms of human experience they might otherwise never know. Similarly, Abdelfattah Kilito [‘Abd al-Fattāḥ Kīlītū]’s work emphasizes the importance of reading literature not merely as a tool of education, but as an epistemic experience through which the reader perceives both the self and the other. For Kilito, reading is a relational practice. As he writes in “Why Read the Classics”, «any reading of a literary text is an encounter with the entire Arabic language» (Kilito 2021) and as such, a meeting with the past that informs our present. Yet, if we take the discussion beyond the academic institution, the question of literature’s relationship to the world remains open and constantly resurfaces. We chose to situate and approach literature as a humanistic tool capable of addressing contemporary problems, among them the societal fragmentation of both the local and global dimensions.

Asking again what literature can teach us becomes a form of disciplinary self-awareness: an affirmation that literature remains central to how we understand life and human connection. Building on this recognition, the roundtable was conceived out of conversations among early-career researchers eager to engage in a shared process of questioning, linking, and dialogue across disciplinary, temporal, and methodologi-

cal boundaries. We stepped back from our current research projects to reflect on the reasons behind choosing them and the ways they led us to reconsider the epistemological powers of literature. In the end, the roundtable was less a sequence of individual contributions arranged in a roughly chronological order, but rather an experiment in collective thinking, where each presentation responded to and expanded upon the insights of the others. The resulting dialogue was not only about Arabic literature but also about how reading practices themselves can generate knowledge, foster communities, and challenge existing hierarchies of meaning.

Adela Provaznikova's contribution opened the discussion by revisiting the didactic literature of the *Nahḍa* and its shifting role in literary history. Through the examples of al-Muwaylihi [al-Muwayliḥī], Zaydan [Zaydān], and Salim al-Khouri [Salīm al-Ḥūrī], she explored how imaginative literature explicitly pronounced its period-specific moral and educational goals but remains instructive until today. The didactic intentions behind 19th-century texts do not delimit the aesthetic, epistemic, historical, and social knowledge these works impart. She showed that learning from literature means attending to its ethical and epistemic frameworks rather than reducing it to ideological content or historical accuracy.

Extending this historical inquiry into another context, Burcu Karahan examined a collection of 1920s Turkish erotica, *Bin Bir Buse (One Thousand and One Kisses)*. Her reading revealed how the stories' surface conservatism concealed irony and agency, challenging moralizing conventions of late Ottoman fiction. Reflecting on her translation of the series, she underscored that reading and translating are acts embedded in power relations, which participate in the circulation and re-signification of marginalized literary voices – an idea that resonated with Adela's concern for literature's ethical dimensions.

The third contribution, by Antonio Pacifico, provided a meta-theoretical bridge. Tracing key epistemological shifts in Arabic literary studies – from philological certainty to positionality and relational and reflexive approaches – he argued that knowledge emerges through networks not simply linking between text and reader, but also authors and institutions. His reflection grounded the roundtable's collective inquiry in an ethics of research and relationality, setting the stage for the following interventions.

The relational perspective on literature was brought into practice by Safinaz Saad. Drawing on Donna Haraway's notion from *Staying with the Trouble*, she read works by Bilal Alaa [Bilāl 'Alā'] and Radwa Ashour [Raḍwā 'Āšūr] as spaces of relational learning, showing how contemporary Arabic literature enacts alternative forms of coexistence in ever-changing surroundings. Her focus on what literature does – rather than what it merely represents – anticipates Giulia's concept of literature as a "relational archive". Safinaz argued that, in her reading, literature moves beyond the educational to the transformational space, actively participating in (re)imagining, (re)shaping, and

sustaining new forms of living together.

Giulia Aiello explored this notion through Lebanese graphic narratives. Reading Omar Khoury [ʿUmar al-Ḥūrī]’s *Yūtūbyā* (*Utopia*, 2009) and Mazen Kerbaj [Māzin Kirbāğ]’s *Bayrūt lan tabkī* (*Beirut Won’t Cry*, 2006), she argued that these works confront the limits of mimesis and foreground the authors’ situated perspective. She emphasized that their creative approach invites readers to engage actively but ethically with their fragmented testimonies. Her reading framed literature as an archive of lived experience that resists closure, but that is intentional and individualized—an idea that connected directly to Bushra Hashem’s discussion of interpretive autonomy.

In the concluding paper, Bushra turned to contemporary Gulf authors Jokha Al-Harhi [Ġawḥā al-Ḥārītī], Laila al-Mutawa [Laylā al-Muṭṭawaʿ], and Mahmoud Trawri [Maḥmūd Tarāwarī]. Rejecting ethnographic readings of their texts, she argued that they should be seen as acts of world-making that claim aesthetic and narrative complexity. Her intervention extended Giulia’s critique of the documentary gaze into the global literary marketplace, questioning how Arabic literature is read and valued.

The discussion that followed, in the plenum, tied these threads together, moving between questions of autonomy and social engagement in the literary field, the ethics of reading and translation, and the material conditions shaping literary production and study. For instance, we problematized the position of literature as an ethnographic source within Middle Eastern Studies, addressing how such readings reduce aesthetic and imaginative dimensions of fiction and the detrimental implications of turning literature into cultural data. Provoked by a question from the audience, we had to acknowledge that, while translation of foreign literary works into Western languages is in many ways beneficial, it also inadvertently creates hierarchies of visibility and quality, shaping what is read, taught, and valued. Ideas of relational knowledge, situated reading, and the affective dimensions of learning emerged as shared concerns. By the end, the roundtable had become a reflection on our own positions as readers and scholars: how we balance critique and empathy. Asking what we can learn from literature thus turned into a question about the kind of knowledge we seek to create, and for whom.

2/ The Two-Day Workshop

The post-conference workshop sought to extend the questions about the kinds of knowledge literature conveys into a broader reflection on how and why we, as emerging scholars, study Arabic literature today. We met in the air-conditioned, spacious rooms of the University of Oslo. We were generously supported by EURAMAL and joined by experienced scholars from its network. Coming from universities in Czechia, Germany, France, Italy, in addition to Norway and Sweden, the differences between our usual work surroundings and where we sat became apparent. Yet the late-summer sunshine softened any sense of distance, and our meetings passed in a collaborative,

relaxed, and highly inspirational atmosphere. The event not only showed the benefits of meeting in person and dedicating time to difficult conversations in general, but precisely by bringing attention to intellectual and material differences, it highlighted the necessity to create a “common language” among European researchers interested in Arabic literatures to foster more collaborative and inclusive but also more widely relevant knowledge production. What we perhaps at first saw as slightly restricting academic conventions in our respective national traditions emerged as fundamental confines that we need to bridge to appreciate each other’s vision of the field.

Educated at universities in different parts of Europe and in Egypt, and with backgrounds in area studies, Arabic philology, and comparative literature, we asked ourselves: What are the questions we tend to ask when approaching Arabic literature? And what do we even mean by that term? Whereas some would argue that it is the text that should dominate literary study and lead the lines of questioning, others highlighted the positionality of the text within the networks of other texts, their creators, receivers, and their social backgrounds. Perhaps the practices and conditions of literature writing, publishing, and reading are more worthy of studying. It transpired that the two broad European traditions dealing with Arabic culture, the methods of close reading and the more sociological approaches, provide the most insight when applied in combination. Textual tradition is inseparable from social practice. However, it is not an easy undertaking to take both into account. This activity depends on individual methodological equipment. Fabio Caiani and Teresa Pepe, who joined us for the session, argued that as much as we should accept interventions from other disciplines (sociology, politics, media studies, etc.) into the study of literature, we should also proactively seek spaces (conferences, research projects) where Arabic literature can provide an alternative lens. They shared confidence in the expertise we acquire by studying literary works, making our work relevant as long as we can connect literature to other human practices.

Reflecting on our educational and professional paths, we were compelled to acknowledge our own limitations and the formative influence of our institutions, which often perpetuated narrow views of the field and served as repositories of deep-rooted Orientalism. Modern and contemporary Arabic literature, in particular, is still frequently regarded as exotic or marginal and continues to require defense, sometimes even within academia itself. We discussed how global and regional hierarchies affect our engagement with local Arab knowledge and the extent to which we are capable of crossing the traditionally delineated boundaries. In response, participants repeatedly returned to the idea of creating “third spaces” such as blogs, podcasts, or public library sessions, through which we might share our work with wider audiences, both in the region and in Europe, and cultivate more dialogic and accessible forms of scholarship.

Given the entrenched hierarchies of seniority in some parts of academia, where PhD candidates are still treated as students, it can be challenging to transform into an

independent scholar with original ideas and the stamina to defend them. The practical steps involved in becoming the desired expert were addressed in a workshop led by Jacob Høigilt, focusing on postdoctoral opportunities, job interview preparation, and book proposals. Following the almost existential line of questioning in the first session, his appeal to seriously consider the mental health effects of the often precarious and lonely, yet also demanding and competitive work in research, resonated with many of us. It reminded us that while we can – and should – strive to create better conditions and build more supportive infrastructure, we must be aware of the reality of the increasingly commodified academia. The pressures on productivity in the context of cuts in public funding for the humanities across Europe result in fewer job openings and spikes in grant application numbers.

During this session, we also understood that if we want to continue reading and studying Arabic literature, not only because we enjoy it, but also because we consider it indispensable to the understanding of Arabic culture and human practice at large, we need to work together. Collaborative projects, which connect across institutional and national boundaries while also transcending methodological and disciplinary boundaries, should be the way forward. In discussions with EURAMAL representatives, including the current President, Lovisa Berg, we agreed that institutions should provide additional support to connect junior scholars with one another and offer opportunities for mentoring from established researchers. While we excitedly brainstormed specific topics to discuss at summer schools, writing retreats, and in virtual reading seminars, we got reminded that organizational work to make such events happen might be rewarding in the end (as it was for us this time), but it is also very time-consuming and requires a lot of individual dedication.

3/ Continuing the Conversation

The time we took away from our ordinary work to reflect and connect felt intense and productive, generating a vision of future projects, networks, and events. Coming back from Oslo, we tempered our initial ambition but continued to plan small, concrete steps. Publishing this report is one way to remind ourselves and others of the unrivalled potential of talking together and getting to know colleagues not only as authors of exciting papers and articles, but also as real people with similar fears, questions, and challenges. Experiences like this invite reflection on the kinds of spaces our field nurtures: whether they support genuine learning rather than performance, and encourage small-scale, dialogic initiatives that complement formal scholarly structures. These appear to be the primary source of intellectual renewal, reinvigorating both individual scholars and the field as a whole.

What made this encounter so fruitful was not only the exchange of ideas but also the format itself: the deliberate combination of textual discussion and meta-academic

reflection, the cross-generational dialogue, and the atmosphere of co-learning rather than evaluation. These elements created an environment in which reading Arabic literature became a shared form of learning, and scholarship was understood as an ongoing educational process. *Nahḍa* didactic stories may have been written with different aims than postmodern comics that narrate the horrors of civil war; Omani family sagas portray twentieth-century social life differently from the alternative bonds imagined in Radwa Ashour's novels. Yet it is precisely this diversity of creative expression in Arabic that justifies its study. Recognizing the distinct contexts, intentions, and aesthetic logics of such works, and understanding how literary inquiry relates to other forms of knowledge about the Arab world, remains essential. Without it, our understanding of Arab cultures would be seriously diminished.

In this light, we see value in sustaining and expanding similar collaborative spaces – where conversation leads to reflection, and reflection leads to community. These notes thus stand as both documentation and invitation: to organize, to create new networks, and to utilize existing ones. For this reason, we wholeheartedly encourage efforts that foster cooperation among Arabic literature scholars across Europe and the SWANA region, making the field more vibrant, diverse, and connected. Initiatives like this may well serve as models for future collaborative work between emerging and established scholars, reminding us that intellectual renewal begins with dialogue.

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